internal committee to investigate the matter. Authorities view the case as politically motivated, especially given that India has designated Pannun as a 'terrorist'. This stand underscores India's broader narrative of combating terrorism and protecting its sovereignty, framing the plot as an isolated criminal act rather than a state-sponsored operation.

For Gupta personally, the guilty plea marks a significant shift from his initial not-guilty stand and could result in a reduced sentence for cooperating with prosecutors. Cooperation might include providing details on other accomplices, which could complicate India's position if he implicates any officials. Facing up to 40 years in prison, his sentencing is set for May 29, 2026. Media reports quote Gupta's family saying he pleaded guilty in part to end the long and exhausting legal battle, that he took "all the blame" on himself rather than turning state's witness.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR INDIA

The 'guilty plea' has implications for Indo-US relations. While the latter has expressed satisfaction with India's initial investigative efforts, the confirmation of the conspiracy in the courts could harden US law enforcement and congressional attitudes. This could lead to increased scrutiny, demands for greater Indian cooperation—on issues such as extradition—or even proposals for sanctions and human rights conditionalities in bilateral agreements. Frank O'Donnell, a senior research advisor at the Asia-Pacific Leadership Network which deals with security challenges in the region, says, "The guilty plea will enable both governments to draw a line under this episode as a lingering issue in their bilateral relationship...a trial would have risked public disclosure of details sensitive and embarrassing to the Indian government."

Observers point out the parallels with Canada's allegations on the 2023 assassination of Sikh separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar there, saying the Pannun case amplifies concerns over India's handling of dissidents among the diaspora. However, some analysts believe the foundational strength of the Indo-US partnership may mitigate long-term damage, although America could use the issue as leverage in negotiations.

The other protagonist in the case, Vikash Yadav, who has an FBI 'wanted' notice out against him, was arrested by the special cell of the Delhi Police in December 2023 in connection with a separate case of extortion and kidnapping. He has been out on bail since April 2024, and remains subject to legal proceedings in India. (If the US formally seeks his extradition, the process is unlikely to move forward since Yadav is facing trial in India—domestic legal proceedings taking precedence under Indian law.)

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- **The case's link to Indian intelligence, Vikash Yadav, has an FBI 'wanted' notice out against him. He's out on bail in another case filed by the Delhi Police**



- **Both India and the US have strong geopolitical incentives to limit the fallout from the incident**

THE DELHI POLICE CASE AGAINST INTEL OPERATIVE VIKASH YADAV WAS SEEN AS A TACTICAL PLOY TO NIX ANY ATTEMPT BY THE UNITED STATES FOR HIS EXTRADITION. THIS, IN TURN, MAY HELP INSULATE INDIA IN THE CASE, TOO

DAMAGE CONTROL

Experts like Harsh V. Pant, vice-president at the New Delhi-based Observer Research Foundation (ORF), have suggested that both India and the US will likely seek to move past this episode quickly in order to build on the recent positive momentum in bilateral relations. "Washington has already expressed satisfaction with India's high-level inquiry into the matter, which indicates that the fallout can probably be contained...but it does highlight the importance of sustained engagement between the national security agencies of both countries, as well as greater caution in handling sensitive issues that could impact core bilateral interests," says Pant, adding that he does not see the case dominating the headlines for much longer.

Ultimately, although the guilty plea increases short-term pressure on New Delhi to ensure accountability and transparency, it also underscores the resilience of bilateral ties. Both countries have strong geopolitical incentives to manage such disputes carefully. Several experts have debated whether Yadav's alleged involvement points to the actions of a 'rogue officer' or a failed covert operation, noting that a credible internal investigation would be essential to prevent lasting harm to relations. At the same time, some analysts have also questioned the profile of the intended target and the strength of the US evidence, reflecting the broader scepticism and political sensitivities surrounding the case. ■